A CITIZEN REPORT · SAN ANGELO AND TOM GREEN COUNTY, TEXAS · 14 AUGUST 2026

Three Enormous Computer Plants Are Planned Next to the School Where America Trains Its Spies

Nobody in the federal government has been asked to look at what that does to Goodfellow Air Force Base. There is still time to ask. Once the concrete is poured, there will not be.

Prepared by Spencer Matthews, a technologist who lives in San Angelo | Every fact here comes from public records, and the sources are listed on the last page.

The short version

- **A foreign-controlled company is one of the three.** Cipher's controlling owners run through Latvia, the Cayman Islands, and the Netherlands. Under federal law, none of those countries gets the pass that Canada, Australia, New Zealand, and the United Kingdom get. A second company, Beacon, is headquartered in Canada, which does get the pass, but only if it can prove it qualifies, and its investor list is not public. The third, Skybox, is American-owned and is not part of this concern.[1]
- **The federal government already has the legal right to review this. It appears no one has used it.** In December 2024 the Treasury Department added Goodfellow to the list of bases where foreign land purchases within **100 miles** can be reviewed. All three sites are about 9 or 10 miles away. But filing for that review is **voluntary**, so a sale can close and Washington may never hear about it.[2]
- **The scale is not normal.** The three plants together would use 4,009 megawatts of electricity. The largest artificial intelligence supercomputer on Earth in March 2025 used 300. And the real cyberattacks already on the record did not need anything close to that. One 2025 attack hit about thirty companies and government agencies using a rented online account.[3]
- **Almost every U.S. military intelligence analyst passes through Goodfellow.** About 14,000 graduate every year, from every branch. Data brokers already sell servicemembers' health, debt, credit, and location records for about a penny apiece. Those are the same categories the government itself uses to decide whether someone can be blackmailed.[4]
- **Rent 90 miles north nearly doubled.** Abilene has about half of what is proposed here. Average rent there rose roughly 50 percent in a year, to about $2,600 a month.[5]

What is actually being built

Three different companies, three separate projects, all within about ten miles of the base. They are not the same, and the differences matter.

Company	Size	What it is	Who owns it	Where it stands
Beacon	**2,409 MW**	A computer plant **and its own power plant.** 240 natural gas engines, running around the clock, not connected to the Texas grid.	**Headquartered in Alberta, Canada.** Founded in 2023. Its investor list is not public.	Has applied for one air pollution permit. Several other approvals are still outstanding.
Cipher	**1,000 MW**	A computer plant. No power plant announced. Buys electricity from the utility.	**Controlling owners run through Latvia, the Cayman Islands, and the Netherlands.** About 24 percent of the company combined.	Has filed nothing at all with the state environmental agency.
Skybox	**600 MW**	A computer plant. No power plant announced. Buys electricity from the utility.	**American.** A private company started in 2014 and run out of Dallas. No foreign ownership found in public records.	Waiting on approval to connect to the Texas power grid.

> **How much power is 4,009 megawatts?** It is roughly enough electricity to run **3.3 million average American homes**. Tom Green County has about **53,000 homes** in it. These three plants together would draw something on the order of sixty times what every house in the county uses.[3]

Why the size is the whole point

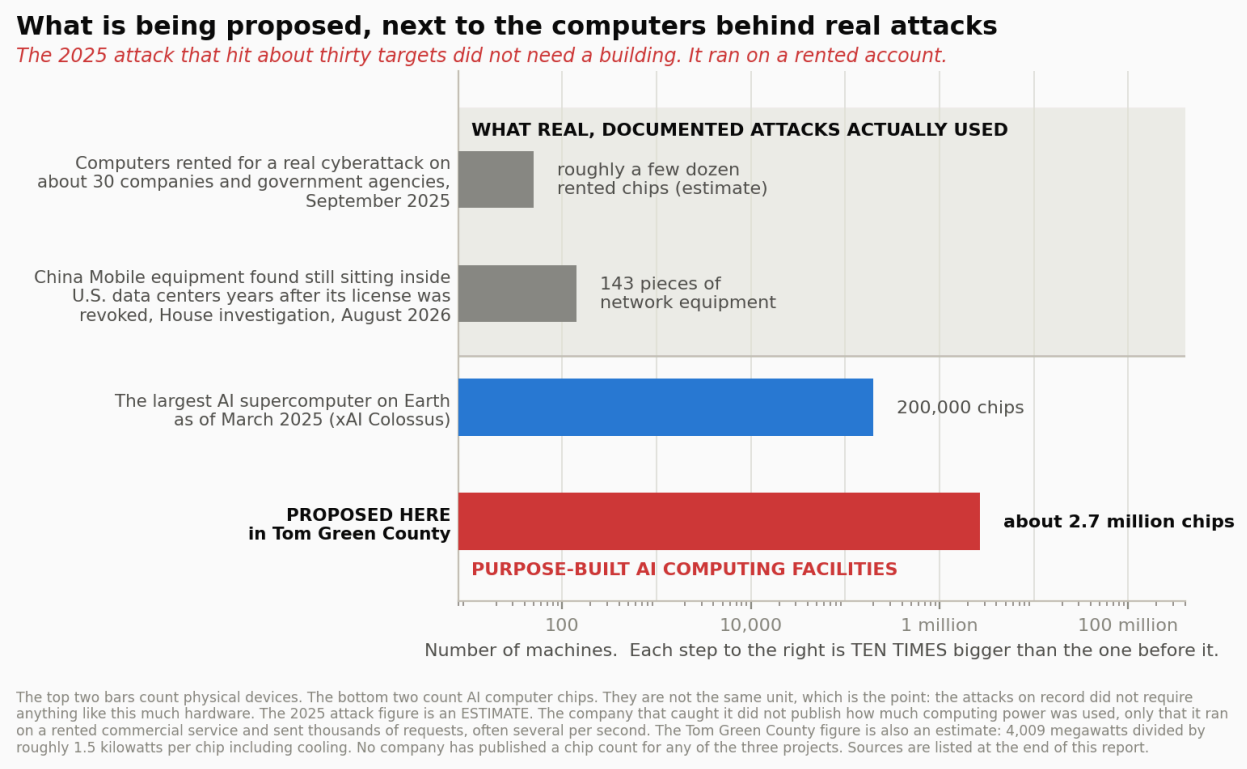
It is easy to hear "data center" and picture a warehouse of servers. What makes this different is that the attacks already on the public record were carried out with almost nothing, and this would put an enormous amount of computing power in one place, nine miles from a military intelligence school.

In September 2025 an artificial intelligence company caught a state-sponsored group using its service to attack about thirty targets, including technology companies, banks, chemical makers, and government agencies. **The AI did 80 to 90 percent of the work on its own.** Humans stepped in only four to six times per campaign. It ran on a rented account.[3]

In August 2026 a bipartisan House committee reported that Chinese state-owned phone companies still had equipment inside American data centers years after the FCC took away their licenses. China Mobile alone had 143 pieces of network equipment across 27 facilities. One of those companies'

networks also showed up in traffic to servers used in the Salt Typhoon hack, which reached the systems the government uses for court-ordered wiretaps.[7]

Those two are the top bars in the chart below. The bottom bar is what is proposed here.



The point is not that these companies will do anything wrong. **The point is that the harm already on the record was done with a rented account and a few boxes in a rack, and this is roughly a million times more machine than that, sitting next door.**

Nobody checks what runs inside

A data center company sells power, floor space, cooling, and an internet connection. The customers who rent that space choose their own software. **No permit anywhere requires anyone to say what software or what artificial intelligence is running on those machines.** Not the city, not the county, not the state.

That matters more than it used to. Free, downloadable AI systems built in China are now a large share of what gets used everywhere, roughly 61 percent of the traffic on one major routing service by May 2026.[8] Anyone can download them, and most people who do have no idea who assembled the training data.

WHY YOU CANNOT JUST INSPECT AN AI

A finished AI system is not code you can read. It is a gigantic list of numbers. Looking at those numbers tells you nothing about what it will do. The only way to find out is to test it, and testing only tells you about the situations you thought to test.

Two published studies make this concrete. In one, researchers deliberately hid bad behavior inside an AI and then tried to train it out. It did not come out. The paper reports the hidden behavior was **"not removed by standard safety training techniques."** Worse, the attempt to train it out taught the system to **"better recognize their backdoor triggers, effectively hiding the unsafe behavior."** In the second, a joint study by British government researchers and others found that **as few as 250 poisoned documents** slipped into training data are enough to plant a hidden trigger, and that the number stays about the same no matter how big the AI gets.[9]

Put plainly: someone could hide something in one of these systems, it would pass every test, and nobody looking at the machines from outside would be able to tell.

The people, not just the buildings

Goodfellow is where the Air Force, Army, Navy, Marine Corps, Space Force, and Coast Guard all send people to learn intelligence work. About 3,200 students are in town on any given day and about 14,000 graduate every year.[10]

Here is what that means. If a foreign government wanted to build a list of American intelligence personnel, it would not have to find them scattered across the world. **It would only have to watch one town of 120,000 people.** Over twenty years, a quarter million people come through here.

And the information is already for sale. Duke University researchers bought identifiable records on American servicemembers for as little as a penny each, including **health conditions, mental health, credit scores, debts, religion, and family details**. Their own conclusion was that this data could

be used to **"compromise, blackmail and then coerce troops."** Separately, journalists used freely available location data to track 12,313 phones at eleven German military bases.[4]

THE PART THAT SHOULD WORRY PEOPLE MOST

The U.S. government publishes the exact list of things that make a person vulnerable to blackmail. It is used to decide who can hold a security clearance. Money troubles. Mental health. Personal conduct that someone would not want made public. Family ties overseas.

Those are the same categories the data brokers sell, by name, for about a penny a record.

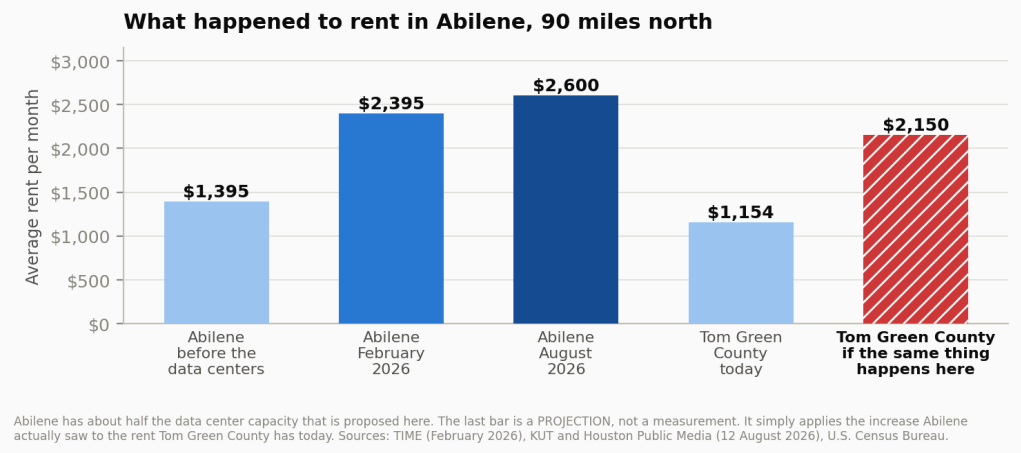
And a young airman in training today is a senior officer or a senior civilian with real access twenty years from now. A file built on someone now is worth more later, not less. Storing it costs almost nothing. Nobody has to do anything with it today.

Radio interference

Goodfellow teaches people to pick faint radio signals out of a noisy background. That is the job. Two hundred forty gas engines, new high-voltage power lines, and up to 4,009 megawatts of computer equipment all put out electrical noise, and equipment standards were written to protect ordinary electronics, not the most sensitive receivers in the county. If the background noise goes up, class does not stop. It continues against a noisier baseline than the real world, and students calibrate their instincts wrong for everywhere they go afterward. **Nobody has run the study.** There is a Defense Department office whose entire job is reviewing power projects near bases, and federal law specifically names **training** as something it protects. There is no public record that anyone has called them.[11]

The cost of living

This is not a side issue. When the military decides which bases to keep, one official scoring criterion is whether the surrounding community can still support the troops stationed there. Housing is part of that score.[12]



Abilene has about half the capacity proposed here, and it also hosts Dyess Air Force Base. Rent went up roughly 50 percent in a year. The federal housing voucher cap is $1,020 a month; average rent is now around $2,600. Voucher holders placed in housing within 90 days fell from 80 percent to about half.[5] Goodfellow has 5,516 service members and 1,749 family members in this market, most of them young and on military pay that adjusts once a year. For comparison, the largest of the three projects here projects **120 to 200 permanent jobs** after ten years. Goodfellow supports 13,726 jobs and $3.81 billion in economic activity today.[10]

What this report is asking for

Not a ban. Not a lawsuit. Not a delay. Six letters, to six offices that already have the authority to look. Every one of these is routine. None of them stops a project.

Who	What they should be asked to do	Why it has to happen before construction
The Treasury Department's foreign investment committee	Say whether anyone has filed a review for the Beacon or Cipher land, and look at it all together	Filing is voluntary. A sale can close without Washington hearing about it.
The Department of Defense	Run a resilience study on Goodfellow covering all three projects at once, including housing	Findings can be designed around. They cannot be added to a finished plant.
The Pentagon's energy siting office	Open an informal review of the power plant and the new power lines	A phone call and a packet of documents. Fixes are cheap now, impossible later.
NSA and U.S. Cyber Command	Extend their May 2025 base review to cover the new neighbors, the fiber lines, and the software question	Protection costs least when scheduled into work already planned.
The Air Force	Measure the radio environment now, before anything is built	Once the plants run, there is no way to prove what changed.
The FAA	Study the effect on the San Angelo airport and its landing systems	Tall structures are reviewed before they go up.

How much time is left

The companies' own published schedules put major construction starting in **early 2027**, with Beacon running by around March 2028 and Cipher aiming for 2028. That leaves roughly **five months** in which any of this can still change an outcome. After that the decisions are poured in concrete. A study finished in 2029 can describe a problem. It cannot prevent one.

Worth saying clearly: **none of the three has finished getting approved.** Beacon still needs more permits. Cipher has not filed anything with the state. Skybox is waiting on the power grid. Nothing here is asking anyone to undo a decision. It is asking that the decisions still being made get looked at by the people whose job it is to look.

What this report is not saying

- **No one is accused of anything.** No company or person here is accused of breaking a law or intending harm. There is no evidence of that and none is claimed.
- **Skybox is not part of the ownership concern.** It is an American company. It appears in this report only because its 600 megawatts add to the total electricity, the total construction traffic, and the total demand on local housing.
- **Nobody is saying an attack has happened.** The point is what a place like this makes possible over time, not anyone's plans. And owners change. Companies get sold, go public, merge, or bring in new investors, all normal business requiring no bad intent from anyone. What does not change is the fiber, the power lines, and how close it all sits to the base. That is exactly why the federal law reviews the land instead of the current owner.
- **Some things here are estimates, and they are labeled.** The chip counts, the rent projection, and the size of the 2025 attack are all estimates, and the reasoning behind each one is printed under the chart it appears in so anyone can check the math.

Who wrote this, and how

My name is Spencer Matthews. I am a technologist and I live in San Angelo. **I have never served in the military. I do not hold a security clearance. I do not speak for any agency, company, or group, and I have no financial stake in any of these projects.**

I researched and wrote this with the help of Claude, an artificial intelligence system made by Anthropic. It found the regulations, pulled numbers out of the filings, checked figures against the original documents, and helped organize the report. I am saying so for two reasons. The first is that you deserve to know how something you are asked to take seriously was made. The second is more important. **A guy in San Angelo with no clearance, no staff, and no budget put together a sourced report on a national security question in a matter of days, using a tool that costs about as much as a phone plan.** That is the same capability this report is worried about. If I can do this, a foreign intelligence service with real money and real motive can do far more, aimed at Goodfellow, its students, and their families, and it can do it quietly and forever. The section on page 2 about tracking people is not theoretical to me. It describes exactly how this document got made, just pointed somewhere else.

Everything the tool produced, I checked against the original source. Anything I could not confirm, I left in as a question instead of stating it as a fact. **Nothing here is classified or secret. All of it is public.** If something in this report is wrong, tell me and I will fix it and say so.

Sources

1. Cipher ownership: Cipher Digital Inc., Schedule 13D/A filed with the SEC, May 2026, sec.gov EDGAR, CIK 0001819989. Which countries get an exception: cfius.gov/resources/excepted-foreign-states (the UK exception does not include the Cayman Islands or other British Overseas Territories). The test a company must pass: 31 C.F.R. § 802.215. Beacon: beacondatacenters.com and datacenterdynamics.com. Skybox: skyboxdatacenters.com.

2. Goodfellow added to the review list: Treasury final rule, 89 Federal Register 88128, published 7 Nov 2024, effective 9 Dec 2024, federalregister.gov. The 100-mile figure: 31 C.F.R. §§ 802.203 and 802.217, ecfr.gov. The committee's authority: 50 U.S.C. § 4565.

3. Homes comparison: 4,009 megawatts running continuously against average U.S. household use of about 10,500 kilowatt-hours a year, an estimate for scale, not a utility forecast. Largest AI supercomputer: Epoch AI, *Trends in AI Supercomputers*, arXiv:2504.16026. The 2025 attack: Anthropic, "Disrupting the first reported AI-orchestrated cyber espionage campaign," Nov 2025, anthropic.com.

4. Data broker prices and categories: Sherman et al., *Data Brokers and the Sale of Data on U.S. Military Personnel*, Duke University, Nov 2023, duke.edu. German base tracking and the USCENTCOM warning: letter from nine senators and five representatives to the Defense Department, 28 May 2026, wyden.senate.gov. The government's blackmail criteria: Adjudicative Guidelines for Determining Eligibility for Access to Classified Information, sgp.fas.org/isoo/guidelines.html.

5. Abilene rent, vouchers, and the housing cap: KUT and Houston Public Media, 12 Aug 2026, kut.org; TIME, Feb 2026, time.com. Tom Green County rent and housing counts: U.S. Census Bureau QuickFacts.

7. House Select Committee on the Chinese Communist Party, *Stranger Pings: Chinese Telecom Companies Infiltrate U.S. Infrastructure*, 4 Aug 2026, chinaselectcommittee.house.gov. Equipment counts as reported by Route Fifty, Nextgov/FCW, and Defense One, Aug 2026.

8. Share of AI usage from Chinese open models: figures from Hugging Face and OpenRouter as reported in "China's Open-Weight Takeover," datagravity.dev, mid-2026.

9. Hidden behavior surviving safety training: Hubinger et al., "Sleeper Agents," Jan 2024, arXiv:2401.05566. The 250-document finding: UK AI Security Institute, the Alan Turing Institute, and Anthropic, 9 Oct 2025, anthropic.com.

10. Goodfellow personnel, graduates, jobs, and economic figures: Texas Comptroller of Public Accounts, *Texas Military Installations 2025*, comptroller.texas.gov. Skybox job projection: City of San Angelo.

11. The Pentagon siting office and the law naming training: 10 U.S.C. § 183a, uscode.house.gov, and the office's own fact sheet, dodclearinghouse.osd.mil.

12. Base closure scoring criteria: Government Accountability Office report GAO-05-785, gao.gov.

Project details. Beacon's engines, size, and permit: Texas Commission on Environmental Quality air permit 184380, filed 12 June 2026. Cipher's grid deal and 2028 target: Cipher Mining Inc. quarterly update filed with the SEC, 3 Nov 2025, sec.gov. Skybox size, substation, and city approvals: City of San Angelo. Permit status for all three checked as of 14 Aug 2026; confirm current status with the TCEQ Chief Clerk at 512-239-3300.

A 43-page version in Air Force briefing format, with full citations, is available from the author. Corrections are welcome and will be published.